

Welcome To The Ricing

Taking Linux Visual Customization To The Next Level

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No, nothing related to the rice you had for dinner last night. Nor are we going to tell you to bury your

Linux machine in rice, and voila you have a Jarvis-like interface on your Linux distro. But what we are going to do is introduce you to the world of ricing, where you tweak your desktop and the desktop experience, with such control and power, that ricing will become a journey instead of a one-time destination.

For starters, pick the nearest internet-connected device in your house and visit the r/UnixPorn subreddit (<https://www.reddit.com/r/unixporn/>), and no, it's not what you think) and check out some of the latest posts. Blown away by how these people have desktops that look so pleasing to eyes and are leagues above the classic looking desktops? So were we.

But the aesthetics of the Unix/Linux realm are well within your reach. Yes, that's right, ricing is mainly focused toward Linux distribution because the amount of flexibility and control they provide to the user over the visual and functional aspect of the OS is far more than what Windows provides or will ever do. So for time being, Windows folks, you have to stick to Wallpaper Engine and Rainmeter (do people still use it?).

MYSTERY OF THE NAME

The term "ricing" made no sense whatsoever to us when we first heard it. What possible connection can "rice" and "computers" have? Well, a bit of digging made things clearer.

In auto terminology, "rice" is an acronym for "Race Inspired Cosmetics Enhancements". These enhancements do not increase the performance of a car whatsoever and the people who do these enhancements to their cars are called "ricers". Now, this term has a negative connotation when it comes to cars because the actual tuners don't like that people just put something on the car that makes it look like it'll go faster but in reality it serves no purpose other than pleasing the eyes.

But when it comes to Unix/Linux customisation there are no just connotations, for the open-source community embraces whatever tinkering the user is capable of doing, whether it is cosmetic shenanigans or kernel coding. One more reason is, the enhancements here aren't just mere "cosmetics". Some people swear by their riced builds and the efficiency it brings to their workflow. All of this might not be making sense to you right now, but by the end of this article, you'll understand what we are saying. *wink* imagine never needing the mouse *wink*.

THE MANY FACETS

When you create your riced up desktop, instead of being one single unit, like say a skin for a media player, it is a modular product with many different parts conjoined to give the end result. Each of these is customisable and editable to your heart's content.

Heck, if you don't like something you can completely remove it from your configuration. For all we know, a terminal and a music player is all you need for a day's work!

Everything mentioned here is open source and free. Most of it is available on GitHub, so you can even get your pimped desktop this weekend. Let's check out the major components:

Operating System:

It's quite understandable that to amp up your desktop you need an operating system, which will provide all the necessary functionalities. Many ricers choose Arch Linux as their preferred choice of the operating system (some hop over to Gentoo, but that distro needs god-like patience), because Arch provides you with full control over the visual aspects of it. The basic installation doesn't even have a desktop! It just throws you in a black terminal and that's it.

Here's what we suggest: install virtualisation software and go haywire. Play around with different distros, follow the innumerable guides on the interweb, get your hands dirty. Once you get comfortable inside the VM, install the Linux on your hard drive and confidently set up your dream desktop.

Desktop Environment:

Next comes the desktop environment or DE. This suite of software gives you everything from a display manager, window manager, file manager, session manager and numerous other default applications that a user expects from an interface. That being said, DE's are basically how you interface with your operating system, i.e the user interface. While Windows and macOS provides a single user interface, here you have the privilege of choosing the one to your liking from many options. Following are the most popular desktop environments, each distro at least uses one of these:

- XFCE: The lightweight king of DE. If you want a DE that is least intensive resources but allows a